



Top of the world: R. Praggnanandhaa has become a household name and continues to be the new flag-bearer for followers of chess in India. R. RAVINDRAN

From this mix, Arjun and Narayanan came up with a series of impressive results without getting their due. Arjun was consistently upstaging higher-rated names from the world elite without winning the title. Narayanan grabbed the bronze in the super-strong Qatar Masters.

In fact, M. Karthikeyan stunned Carlsen in the Qatar Masters and became the only Indian after Anand to do so in a classical time format.

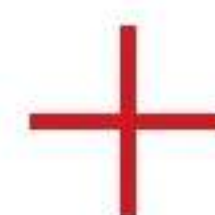
This made Hikaru Nakamura, Carlsen's long-time rival, tweet, "This is the future for him (Carlsen). The Indians are coming for him. It's going

to be one Indian after another, after another, after another—all the disciples of Vishy."

In the blitz format, birthday boy Gukesh defeated Carlsen in Norway chess.

Among the women, Vaishali was the one that grabbed the most attention as the year drew to a close. After decades ruled by Humpy, followed by Harika, the rise of Vaishali to the elite top-15 gladdened the hearts of Indian chess followers. At present, Humpy (2nd), Harika (12th), and Vaishali (14th) stand in this order in the world ranking list.

Vaishali's status and stature were elevated after she won the Grand Swiss and qualified for Candidates. She went on to become only the third Indian woman to become a Grandmaster. After collecting her



Highlights of 2023

Praggnanandhaa finished runner-up to Magnus Carlsen in the World Cup; Four Indians reached the semifinals.

Five qualified for Candidates Tournaments.

Vidit Gujrati and R. Vaishali scripted an Indian sweep in Grand Swiss

Gukesh snapped Anand's 37-year old reign as the highest rated Indian in World list.